to have taken the trouble, not only to verify the correct status but also to have given me a call. When all of us are on the same page, it is that much easier to formulate the proper response.

But Covid or no Covid, work has to go on. In the Army, we have to achieve our tasks despite the obstacles in between, be it minefields or barbed wire. Covid was just another obstacle that had to be overcome in the accomplishment of the task. While the rest of the country was going into lockdown and working from home mode, I felt that this would not do for me as the Chief or, for that matter, for other Commanders on the ground. We have been groomed to lead from the front, to be with our men at the time and place where it matters most. The Army Chief couldn't be sequestered in his office but had to be seen in order to instil confidence in the rank and file. Accordingly, I continued with my visits to units and formations in field areas as well as peace stations. The only restriction I placed was that there would be no large gatherings, particularly evening parties. Even my address to the troops was carried out in open spaces with adequate social distancing.

I had served mostly in Northern and Eastern Commands, that too in field areas. Hence, I felt that rather than covering the same old ground, I should instead familiarize myself with those areas I had not been to earlier or visited only many years earlier. I started in the Area of Responsibility of Southern Command, South to North, from Sir Creek along the Rann of Kutch and then into Rajasthan, with halts at Bhuj, Koteswar, Munabao, Jaisalmer and Tanot. Over a period of two days, I listened to the briefings of the Commanding Officers and Brigade Commanders at their actual operational locations and not on some sand model well in the rear, and also interacted with the troops over tea with shakarparas and mathhari—no fancy cookies or pastries. At Koteswar, there were also detachments

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